1NT (15-17)

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The modern, strong 1NT opening shows a balanced hand with 15-17 HCP. In the old days, 1NT showed 16-18 HCP, which has fallen out of favor due to its lower frequency.

Examples of hands suitable for a 1NT opening:

♠A873 ♥AJ42 ♦AJ2 ♣KT	♠K97 ♥T2 ♦K87 ♣AKQ43	♠AJ ♥876 ♦AK98 ♣KT32	♠AKQ ♥KQJ2 ♦J65 ♣987

Shape

1NT promises balanced suit distribution without any singletons or voids, namely:

- 4-4-3-2
- 4-3-3-3
- 5-3-3-2

However, 1NT may also be opened on semi-balanced distribution:

- 2-2-3-6 (a long minor)
- 2-2-4-5 (excluding length in both majors)

In "Commonsense Bidding", Bill Root cites the following semi-balanced hand as an example of distributed strength suitable for 1NT:

♠K2
♥AQ
♦AT75
♣KT942

With a 5-Card Major

The SAYC bidding system states that 1NT "can be made with a five-card major". This is up to partnership agreement.

The advantages of opening 1NT with a 5-card major:

- It's slightly more preemptive. It's riskier for the opponents to overcall 2♠ over 1NT than to overcall 1♠ over 1♥.

- It's more descriptive. Your point range and balanced shape are immediately shown, whereas a 1♥/♠ opening bid may be made on all kinds of hand patterns and strengths.

The disadvantage of opening 1NT is the danger of missing a major-suit fit. This can happen whenever partner holds 3- or 4-card support:

- She passes 1NT with a weak hand.
- She passes a 2-level overcall. Now you must decide whether to introduce your major at the 2-level.
- She makes a Jacoby Transfer when you only have doubleton support.

Consequently, partnerships may have special agreements with a 5-card major (up for discussion):

- Opening 1NT with 3 cards in the other major, in case partner makes a transfer bid.
- Opening 1NT with evenly distributed high-card strength.
- Opening 1NT with 5 hearts. With 5 spades, consider opening 1♠.

Responses

The following responses are consistent with the SAYC bidding system, which is comparable to any generic 5-card major system. However, variations always apply and these responses should not be considered universal for all bidding systems.

Response	Meaning
Pass	0-7 points, no 5-card major (use a Jacoby Transfer instead) and no 6-card minor (bid 2♠ to relay to your minor suit).
2♣	Stayman, showing 8+ points and at least one 4-card major. However, it typically excludes hands with 4-3-3-3 shape.
2♦	A Jacoby Transfer, showing 5+ hearts.
2♥	A Jacoby Transfer, showing 5+ spades.
2♠	Artificial, showing a weak 6+ card minor suit. Opener is required to bid 3♣. Responder will pass or correct to 3♦. Minor-Suit Stayman is a popular non-SAYC alternative to this approach.
2NT	Invitational to 3NT. Shows 8-9 HCP and balanced shape. Denies a 4-card major unless holding 4-3-3-3 shape.
3♣	6+ clubs, 7-8 HCP. Invitational to 3NT. As an alternative approach, it may simply be a weak sign-off bid. This method is espoused by expert Richard Pavlicek, among others.
3♦	6+ diamonds, 7-8 HCP. Same comments as 3♣, above.
3♥	6+ hearts with slam interest. However, this agreement rarely comes up. Many players would simply start with a Jacoby Transfer.
3♠	6+ spades with slam interest. Same comments as 3♥, above.
3NT	Natural, 10-13 HCP.
4♣	Gerber, an artificial ace-asking bid.
4NT	Quantitative, inviting 6NT.

In Competition

- If the opponents double 1NT, then Stayman and Jacoby Transfers are still "on".
- If the opponents overcall 1NT, then Jacoby Transfers are "off". However, Stayman may still be possible via a cuebid.
- If the opponents double a 2♦/♥ Jacoby Transfer, then opener is allowed to pass with only 2-card support.

As a non-SAYC alternative, the Lebensohl convention can be used to show a variety of hand types if the opponents double or overcall through 2♠.

See also

- 1NT Calculator
  Evaluates a hand for a potential 1NT opening bid.
- Gerber
  An ace-asking convention in no-trumps slam auctions.
- Jacoby Transfers
  Transfer bids after partner opens the bidding in no-trumps.
- Stayman
  A convention for responding to 1NT to find a 4-4 major-suit fit.

